# Golden Silence and active observation

Launching independent practice

Use Golden Silence and active observation to protect the launch of independent practice. Establish the working norm, then alternate purposeful circulation with a view of the whole class.

## How to do it well

**1 Prepare the launch.** Give clear instructions, a stuck protocol and a useful finish task, then check listening before release.

**2 Protect Golden Silence.** Use a brief period of visible whole-class observation to establish independent effort.

**3 Circulate purposefully.** Inspect a specific feature of early work along a planned route and give short targeted feedback.

**4 Step back and decide.** Regain a view of the room, identify participation gaps and distinguish individual need from a common error.

**5 Continue or reset.** Preserve productive practice, use a brief class repair when justified, or a planned discussion break followed by renewed independent work.

## What this sounds like

“Begin independently. I will watch the first thirty seconds, then check first attempts. If you need help, identify the step that is unclear while continuing what you can.”

**Classroom example.** After checking instructions, the teacher protects a brief silent launch from a position with a whole-room view. Circulation then checks first attempts along a route, followed by a step back to inspect participation. A targeted prompt is revisited later. The teacher avoids spending the opening minutes absorbed at one desk.

## Top tips that make the technique work

**Protect roughly the first thirty seconds.** Stand where you can see the room, recognise the expected start and correct unobtrusively.

**Use 30:30:30 flexibly.** A brief launch, circulation period and step-back observation can stop individual support absorbing all attention.

**Eliminate blackspots.** A planned route should reach every part of the room, not just raised hands.

**Give one precise intervention.** Prompt the next step, check it was heard and return after the student works.

**Use 4–2 cycles selectively.** A short independent burst followed by paired checking can sustain thinking when it serves the task; it is not a compulsory timer routine.

## Do and avoid

| Do | Avoid |
|---|---|
| Secure the start before extended individual help. | Circulating into a long conversation immediately. |
| Step back regularly to observe the whole room. | Treating silent appearance as evidence that everyone is thinking. |

## Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

Barton — Maximising participation during independent practice